

INNER BELT SECTOR // ASTEROID HABITAT

ORESTES-7

A NOVELLA OF THE BELT

Complete 7-Chapter Edition

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The Glass Booth & Article 45

The air on Orestes-7, a dense nickel-iron asteroid floating on the inner rim of the Belt, always tasted like scorched copper and wet dust.

Marek was 46 years old, and he knew that smell down to his teeth.

Every morning started the same way. He'd swing his legs out of a pressurized bunk barely wider than his shoulders, slip into a worn, faded grease-stained jumpsuit, and walk down the narrow conduits to Sub-Level 4. He wasn't a hero, a pilot, or a pioneer. He was an Audit Log Verifier for the station's automated slag refining bay.

By law—specifically the Inter-System Labor Preservation Act passed two centuries ago—corporations could not run 100% automated operations. Even though the heavy industrial "Scotty" units and third-generation autonomous dredges handled 98% of the actual extraction, mining conglomerates were legally forced to maintain a 25% human labor quota.

In practice, this meant Marek spent twelve hours a day sitting in a tiny glass-walled booth above a churning pit of molten iron. Every eleven minutes, a terminal would chime, presenting him with a blue diagnostic screen. His job was to look at a sensor read-out, compare two numbers generated by a machine, and tap a green icon to confirm the machine hadn't lied to itself.

It was soul-crushing work designed purely to satisfy a tax credit.

Marek wasn't a bad guy. He didn't start fights in the galley, he paid his air tax on time, and he nodded politely in the corridors. But people kept their distance. He had the restless, sharp-eyed look of someone who had never accepted the quiet, numb routine everyone else survived on. He had spent his twenties bouncing from one dead-end maintenance berth to another, disqualified from deep-fleet academy duty due to a minor ventricular murmur and calcified lung tissue from early-life scrubber failures.

He had ground out twenty-five years in dusty rock stations while younger, healthier recruits flew the heavy ore haulers out to Europa and Titan.

On his 46th birthday, the system changed.

Under solar maritime code, Article 45 was an unwritten pact between the corporations and the older belt dwellers: If you survive to 45 in the rock stations, your health restrictions drop. The corporate logic wasn't merciful—it was economic. At 45, your long-term health liabilities start going up anyway, so the fleet waives medical disqualifications for high-risk, low-tier berths. If an old clerk with bad lungs wants to risk dying in deep space, it saves the station a pension payout.

Marek stood in front of his terminal during his lunch break, watching the amber status tag on his profile flip from RESTRICTED: HABITAT ONLY to ELIGIBLE: EXPENDABLE FLEET AUXILIARY.

He wasn't under any illusion that he was about to become a starship captain. The universe 700 years out wasn't romantic; it was industrial, expensive, and indifferent. But sitting on his screen were three realistic, gritty options to finally get off Orestes-7:

The Mars "Scotty" Scrap Sweeper (Surface & Low-Orbit Salvage)

The Job: Mars had been terraformed enough for surface survival with basic rebreathers, but the surface was still littered with thousands of defunct, highly radioactive early-generation "Scotty" terraforming units buried under dust storms. The pay was decent, but it involved cutting apart decayed nuclear reactor housings that automated bots refused to touch due to logic loop errors.

The Reality: Dirty, back-breaking ground work in freezing dust storms. High radiation exposure, but he'd finally stand on a planet with an atmosphere, even if it tasted like iron grit.

Trojan Ice-Scraper (Jupiter Belt Haulage)

The Job: Deep-space ice extraction in the Trojan asteroids around Jupiter. The ships were massive, rusted water-hulks running low-acceleration routes that took months in near-isolation. High-risk, zero-g work anchoring physical thermal drills into tumbling ice-rocks.

The Reality: Long stretches of absolute silence, high cosmic radiation, and claustrophobic quarters shared with four other late-career dropouts. However, it paid out high hazard credits and put him on an actual ocean-going vacuum vessel.

Ghost-Hull Demolition (Ceres Graveyard Shift)

The Job: Scrap crew for decommissioned orbital habitats and dry-docks around Ceres. Old, abandoned stations from the mid-colonization era were structural hazards. Human crews were brought in to manually set plasma charges and strip high-value copper-alloy wiring before the hulls were pushed into the sun.

The Reality: Extremely dangerous zero-g EVA work. The hazard rate was high due to micro-meteoroid punctures and structural collapse, but it offered short contract cycles—three months on, one month off.

Marek stared at the glowing amber options, his cold tea sitting untouched beside the console. For twenty years he had dreamed of breaking out of the glass booth. Now that the door was unlocked, every choice smelled like a different kind of danger.

Playing the Queue

Marek didn't rush to his terminal. In a system like this, enthusiasm was just a fast track to getting screwed.

He knew how the maritime algorithms played the game. The second your Article 45 flag flipped green, every desperate fifty-something on the rock slammed the submission button. The system's response was predictably cruel: your application sat in PENDING for three to six weeks while a corporate sorting program quietly prioritized applicants with minor administrative favors or higher labor credits.

Then came the rejection notification, attached to a "Priority Alternative": *Position filled. However, an immediate opening exists for 90 days of manual ice-chipping on an unshielded surface ridge. Confirm within four hours.*

If you took it, you broke your back in a vacuum for pennies. If you refused, the system logged it as a "declined deployment" and dumped you straight to the back of the regional waitlist—position #18,400. You'd be fifty before your name floated to the top again.

Marek was patient because he had watched dozens of guys fall for that exact loop. Every few months, when a heavy haulage convoy rotated through or a bulk station decommission was authorized, the system hit a sudden labor deficit. When that happened, the algorithms stopped playing gatekeeper and dumped hundreds of real, legitimate berths onto the board all at once, taking anyone with an active, un-trapped application.

The trick was knowing when the floodgates were about to open—and for that, you couldn't rely on the station's official comms feeds. You had to go talk to people.

He pulled on his heavy canvas jacket and stepped out into the central conduit of Orestes-7.

The station was nearly three hundred years old, and it smelled like it. The air didn't taste like deep space; it tasted like three centuries of damp clothing, fried synthetic yeast, and stale humidity filters. The rock had been hollowed out back when the Belt was still wild, but all the romance had long since been scraped away.

Anyone who had real dirt in their blood—the actual pioneers, the risk-takers, the dreamers—had left generations ago for the Outer Moons or the cloud stations around Venus. What remained on Orestes-7 was the sediment: generations of people

perfectly content to live in a dark, pressurized tin can, working twelve-hour shifts, gossiping about their neighbors' air-ration allowances, and dying in the same bunk they were born in.

Marek hated them. He hated their smallness, their tight-knit family cliques that guarded the good administrative shifts, and the way they looked at anyone who didn't spend their off-hours in the central mess hall playing dominoes. But beneath the spite, there was a bitter thread of envy. He wished he could be like them. He wished he could just sit in a plastic chair, drink lukewarm chicory, talk trash about the sector supervisor, and feel like this damp tunnel was enough.

He walked past the main observation gallery. Through the thick lead-glass port, he could see a section of the asteroid's outer hull. A cluster of slick, identical silver drones was quietly welding a micro-meteoroid patch onto the primary shield array. Beside them stood three human technicians in high-grade, zero-g pressure suits emblazoned with the logo of Sol-Standard Infrastructure.

They weren't locals. They were specialized corporate contractors—genetically screened, medically pristine kids brought in from the inner stations to do the high-skill structural maintenance. The locals weren't even allowed to touch the external hull plating. The corporations didn't trust asteroid dwellers with anything that actually mattered.

Even the local "maintenance" jobs were an insult. Marek remembered his six-month stint three years ago assigned to "food-synth maintenance." He had spent two weeks walking alongside an Aegis-4 maintenance drone to service a broken ration bar dispenser in Sector 3.

"Insert hex-wrench into bolt A," the machine's synthetic voice had droned in his ear.
"Turn 180 degrees counter-clockwise. Stop. Do not touch the internal wiring. I will handle the optical sensor replacement."

Marek was literally just a pair of thumbs with a heartbeat, legally required to stand there so the company could check off its 25% human labor quota on its tax return. If he had dropped his wrench, the robot probably would have picked it up for him and apologized for the inconvenience.

He turned down the narrow, dimly lit pipe-works of Sub-Level 2, heading toward the rear of the station's atmospheric scrubber plant.

If anyone knew when the next heavy convoy cycle was actually dropping, it was Koval.

Koval was fifty-eight, missing two fingers on his left hand from an old hydraulic accident, and ran the station's pneumatic supply dispatch. He was one of the few people Marek could tolerate—mostly because Koval was just as cynical about the Belt as Marek was, but had long since traded his frustration for a steady supply of contraband home-brew and black-market station gossip.

Marek knocked on the heavy steel door of the dispatch office. A muffled grunt came from inside, followed by the metallic clatter of a wrench hitting a desk.

"It's open," Koval barked. "Unless you're from Environmental Safety, in which case the leak was already like that when I got here."

Marek pushed the door open, slipping into the cramped, grease-scented office. "It's me, Koval."

Koval looked up from an ancient data-slate, his bloodshot eyes narrowing through the haze of a synthetic vapor-cig. He looked Marek up and down, taking in the slightly cleaner jumpsuit and the restless edge in his posture.

"Well, well," Koval muttered, leaning back in his squeaky vinyl chair. "The ghost of Sub-Level 4. I heard your profile tag flipped amber this morning. Happy forty-sixth, Marek. You officially qualify to die in vacuum instead of slow-cooking in the slag pits."

"I haven't submitted my deployment preferences yet," Marek said, sitting down on an upturned crate of air filters. "I know how the queue works."

"Good. Then you're slightly less of an idiot than young Miller from Sector 2," Koval snorted, spitting into a metal scrap bucket. "Kid turned forty-five last month, clicked 'apply' on the first Jupiter ice-hauler option he saw. Got rejected in ten days, turned down the surface-scrape counter-offer, and now he's sitting at position nineteen thousand. He'll be fifty-two before his name comes up again."

"That's why I'm here," Marek said, leaning forward. "What's coming through the sector? Real fleet stuff. Not corporate scrap duty."

Koval tapped the side of his data-slate, thinking for a moment. He glanced toward the heavy door to make sure it was latched, then leaned over his desk.

"You didn't hear it from me," Koval murmured. "But the Ceres Logistics Bureau is pulling three heavy ore-carriers out of mothballs in six weeks. The automated navigation suites on those old rust-buckets are fourth-gen—totally obsolete, prone to

logic drift in heavy magnetic fields. Standard protocol says they can't run them automated without a five-man human oversight crew per ship. Auxiliary mechanics, riggers, deck hands."

Marek felt his chest tighten slightly. "Real berths?"

"Real berths," Koval confirmed. "Deep-run routes down to the Saturn rings. Long, ugly, quiet. But it's actual fleet time on a hull that moves. The corporate bulletin hasn't posted the manifest yet because they're still arguing over fuel credits with the Belt Authority. If you drop your application into the system the morning that manifest hits, you bypass the queue trap entirely."

"Six weeks," Marek said softly, calculating the days in his head. "Six weeks sitting in the glass booth, stamping diagnostic logs while the local gossips talk about who's getting the new hydroponic tomato allotment."

"Six weeks is nothing," Koval said, pointing a grease-stained finger at Marek's chest. "You've waited twenty-five years on this rock, Marek. Don't ruin it now by being impatient. You sit in your booth, you tap your green buttons, you nod at the idiots in the corridor, and you wait for my signal."

Ring 3 & The Existential Dread

Marek walked the high-concourse of Ring 3, his hands shoved deep into the pockets of his canvas jacket.

The main thoroughfare was crowded with the usual afternoon shift-change traffic. Overhead, neon-lit commercial feeds buzzed against the raw, spray-concrete archway of the cavernous tunnel. Down here, everyone was glued to their slates or standing in tight, agitated groups outside the communal canteens.

The entire station was currently in a state of civil war over the "One-Pad" directive.

The habitat board had proposed a resource-conserving amendment restricting lower-tier domestic units to a single networked terminal pad per household. To hear the locals tell it, you'd think the corporate board was coming to strangle their children in their bunks. Marek had walked past Betty—a forty-year veteran of the water-reclamation desk—standing on a plastic crate outside the central galley, red-faced and waving her arms, ranting to a crowd of twenty people about "digital disenfranchisement." On the other side of the walkway, a pair of habitat loyalists were shouting back, calling her a bandwidth hoarder.

Marek walked right through the middle of the noise, invisible to them. He operated on a completely different frequency.

He looked at them with a mix of disgust and cold detachment. They live in a hollowed-out iron rock suspended in an endless, freezing void, and they're ready to draw blood over who gets a second screen in their sleeping cubicle.

It was all so absurdly, painfully small. But then again, the whole system was built on absurdity.

As he walked past the glowing orange glow of a public job kiosk, his mind cycled back to the maritime algorithm. The queue logic was completely braindead. Out of the 15,000 regional names currently listed on the Belt-wide labor roster, Marek knew that maybe 300 were actually, genuinely interested in deep-space work. Out of those 300, maybe twenty were actually competent—guys with real spatial awareness and cold nerves.

And yet, the corporate algorithm didn't give a damn about qualification.

If a disgraced former atmospheric shuttle pilot with two thousand hours of flight time was sitting at position #1,040 on the ledger, he would get passed over every single time for a guy who turned forty-six yesterday and happened to hit the

"SUBMIT" button three milliseconds after a server refresh. The algorithm prioritized immediate submission speed over skill, simply because it was easier for the sorting software to clear active flags than to evaluate human merit. Marek knew how to leverage that flaw—Koval had just handed him the exact timestamp for the Ceres update—but the fact that the entire industrial infrastructure of the solar system was run on such a lazy, mechanical illusion made his teeth ache.

It was the same artificiality that governed his entire working life.

Take the 12-hour shift standard. It was a joke. Human cognitive focus degraded off a cliff after forty-five minutes of staring at a diagnostic loop. In his booth above the slag pits, Marek was sharp for maybe half an hour. After that, his brain went entirely numb. For the remaining eleven and a half hours, his right hand operated on pure muscle memory, tapping the green "VERIFY" icon every time the chime sounded.

On some of the high-security inner stations, the automated systems intentionally introduced fake logic errors into the feed once every forty hours just to make sure the human supervisor hadn't died of a heart attack or fallen asleep. On Orestes-7, they didn't even bother with the test errors. Marek had worked four years in Sub-Level 4 and had never seen a single discrepancy. He was a piece of decorative meat legally required to sit in a chair so the station manager could claim a tax exemption.

If they ran four-hour shifts with focused crews, human life on the asteroid would actually be tolerable. But the 12-hour block was an ancient, rusted relic of 21st-century labor contracts that nobody had the energy to rewrite. So people sat for half a day doing nothing, then took three days off to scream at each other in the corridors about home terminal quotas.

Marek paused near the end of the concourse, resting his forearm against the icy metal handrail of a secondary observation deck.

He thought about the history holos he used to skim when he was a kid. Seven hundred years ago, back on Earth, history had weight. Humans dropped atomic weapons on each other, fought over entire continents, collapsed nations, and built terrifying, desperate technologies just to survive. It was brutal and ugly, but the stakes were real.

Now? Humanity had reached the stars, but instead of an era of grand conquest, they had brought along an army of safety lawyers, compliance software, and automated "Scotty" units. Space wasn't wild anymore; it was an endlessly managed, sanitized corporate holding pattern where humans were kept around like vestigial organs.

Then, a cold, heavy lump formed in the pit of his stomach.

He stared out through the thick, scratched lead-glass port of the observation deck. Out there, past the blinking red navigation lights of the docking bay, was the black. Absolute, unyielding, six-week-away Ceres transit routes.

The existential dread hit him suddenly, paralyzing his knees.

For twenty-five years, Marek had built his entire identity around being the bitter outsider. He was the guy who hated Orestes-7, the guy who was too big for this rock, the guy who was trapped by a medical flag and a corrupt system. His frustration had been his armor. It gave him a reason to wake up every morning: *I'm better than this place, and one day I'm getting out.*

But now, Koval's words echoed in his head. The Ceres manifest was real. In six weeks, he was actually going to hit that button at the exact right millisecond. He was actually going to get a berth on a rusted, deep-run ore-carrier bound for the Saturn outer ring.

And for the first time in his life, Marek was terrified.

What if he got out there into the deep vacuum, sitting on an obsolete ship with four other desperate, washed-up fifty-year-olds, and realized that the problem wasn't Orestes-7? What if the hollow, suffocating feeling wasn't the station air, but something inside his own chest?

He watched a heavy cargo drone slowly align itself with the lower airlock, its cold thrusters firing in precise, silent bursts. The red light reflected off Marek's pale face in the glass. He couldn't go back to the glass booth and be happy, but stepping forward felt like stepping off a cliff into total darkness.

The Drop Window

Koval's original six-week estimate had dragged into six agonizing months.

Corporate squabbling over fuel subsidies, legal battles between the Belt Authority and Ceres Logistics, and endless orbital window recalculations had frozen the fleet rollout. For half a year, Marek had lived in a state of suspended animation, going to his glass booth in Sub-Level 4 every morning, tapping his green icons, and wondering if Koval's leak had been a lie.

Now, there were less than twenty-four hours left.

He was losing his mind.

He couldn't sleep. Every time he closed his eyes in his narrow bunk, his heart hammered against his ribs like a trapped bird. He couldn't eat; the synthetic protein paste tasted like wet chalk and sat in his stomach like lead. His entire world had shrunk down to a single numeric readout on his wall-mounted pad.

Worse than the waiting was the creeping, absurd paranoia. He spent three hours staring at the flickering light conduit above his door, terrified of a station-wide power outage. Power failures on Orestes-7 were exceedingly rare—he could only recall one major grid reset in his entire forty-six years—but today, he was convinced the primary reactor ring would collapse at 07:59:59. He wiped his palms on his trousers every thirty seconds, convinced that sweat on his fingertips would fail the terminal's thermal contact sensor.

All the impatience, resentment, and desperate longing he had suppressed for twenty-five years had boiled up to the surface at once. His hand trembled so violently he could barely hold his chicory mug.

He sat cross-legged on his bunk, refreshing the corporate bulletin feed every two minutes. Refresh. Refresh. Refresh.

He knew it was useless. The algorithmic drop was hard-coded for 08:00:00 station time. But the logic in his brain had completely broken down. Time didn't feel like a stream anymore; it felt like a thick, suffocating tar. Seconds stretched into hours, hours into centuries.

07:58:12
07:58:45
07:59:10

Marek hovered his thumb three millimeters above the glass. His breathing was shallow, raspy, echoing loudly in the tight sleeping cell.

07:59:58
07:59:59

The terminal screen flashed. The blue corporate banner dissolved, replaced by a glaring, amber-bordered system notification:

CERES HEAVY FLEET RE-COMMISSION — AUXILIARY CREW MANIFEST OPEN

Muscle memory took over. Twenty-five years of tapping diagnostic buttons in Sub-Level 4 fired through his nervous system before his brain could even process the words. Tap. Select: Hull Maintenance / Rigging. Confirm. Submit.

The screen froze for a fraction of a heartbeat. Marek's throat locked.

Then, the interface shifted to a neutral, flat grey:

[REGISTRATION RECEIVED]
APPLICANT ID: 488-729-A
DESIRED BERTH: CERES HEAVY AUXILIARY OVERSIGHT
STATUS: PENDING QUEUE PROCESSING

He sat frozen, his chest heaving. He refreshed the page. PENDING.

A cold wave of distrust washed over him. His personal pad was old—what if the localized mesh-network on Ring 3 had dropped a packet? What if the ping hadn't registered at the central relay?

Unable to sit still, Marek bolted out of his bunk, threw open his compartment door, and practically ran down the pipelined corridor to the sector's main infrastructure junction. His boots clattered against the iron grating, the noise echoing through the quiet sub-level.

He slammed his hand against the frame of the heavy iron public kiosk node on the corner of Ring 3. He shoved his data key into the slot and pulled up his regional profile on the hard-wired station network.

The heavy glass monitor hummed, displaying the master ledger line:

```
USER 488-729-A (MAREK) — APPLICATION RECEIVED  
TIMESTAMP: 08:00:00.104  
STATUS: PENDING  
CENTRAL ALGORITHM PROCESSING IN PROGRESS
```

It was real. His application was logged at barely one-tenth of a second after the drop. He had done his part. He had played the system as perfectly as any human could.

Marek leaned his forehead against the cold, industrial casing of the public terminal, closing his eyes. His body was shaking from the adrenaline crash, but there was no relief—only a vast, terrifying emptiness.

Speed didn't matter anymore. Strategy didn't matter anymore. His frantic, trembling energy had nowhere left to go. The decision was entirely out of his hands, trapped deep inside the cold, unfeeling circuitry of an orbital server cluster miles away, where a sorting script would decide whether he spent his remaining years in a glass booth or out in the freezing deep.

CHAPTER V

Rejection & Breakdown

The system's response didn't take three weeks. It didn't even take three days.

It came on a quiet Tuesday afternoon, a flat, cold chime on his wall terminal while he was sitting on the edge of his bunk, staring at the floor.

```
[ NOTIFICATION: APPLICATION STATUS UPDATE ]  
APPLICANT ID: 488-729-A  
BERTH: CERES HEAVY AUXILIARY OVERSIGHT  
RESULT: UNFULFILLED – CANDIDATE SELECTION CONCLUDED  
REASON: QUALIFICATION PREFERENCE MET BY ALTERNATE APPLICANTS
```

When Marek read the lines, his legs simply gave out.

He didn't scream. He didn't punch the metal partition. He dropped straight onto the thin mattress, his chest collapsing as if the station's atmospheric pressure had suddenly spiked. A wave of profound, sickening weakness washed through him, draining the strength out of his arms until he couldn't even keep his hands from shaking.

Then came the boiling, poison heat.

A dark, chaotic rage erupted behind his eyes—a white-hot hatred directed at everything and everyone. He hated Koval for handing him a useless fairytale. He hated Betty and the idiots screaming on the concourse about their terminal pads. He hated the sleek, pristine corporate kids in their high-grade pressure suits. He hated the station manager, the slag pit, the air scrubbers, and the very rock under his boots.

For ten violent minutes, his mind spun out of control. Dark, reckless thoughts flared in the quiet darkness of his cubicle: *I could open an airlock valve in Sub-Level 4. I could find Koval and break his jaw with a hex-wrench. I could crawl into the unshielded exhaust conduit and let the thermal purge turn me to ash.*

He had done everything right. He had waited twenty-five years. He had played their stupid game, tracked the timestamps down to a tenth of a second, and held his breath for six months.

And then, the station chatter started filtering through the ventilation ducts.

The gossips in the corridor outside were already talking about it. The Ceres berth wasn't a rumor; three actual crewed ore-carriers were pulling out of dry dock, and a handful of local names had actually been selected. But they weren't audit clerks or button-stampers. They were former fleet technicians—guys with actual flight hours, zero-g welding certifications, and decades of heavy rigging experience who had been waiting for a real ship to open up.

The realization hit Marek like a physical blow to the head, knocking the rage right out of him and leaving behind a hollow, agonizing shame.

Of course.

How could he have been so blind? How could he have been so pathetic, so utterly, arrogantly stupid?

He had convinced himself that the entire solar system was run by a blind, braindead algorithm that rewarded whoever hit a button first. He had comforted himself for decades with the bitter illusion that he was better than everyone else on Orestes-7, trapped only by bad luck and a bad heart.

But when real spaceflight was on the line—when actual corporate hulls were moving into deep vacuum—the system wasn't stupid at all. It didn't want an old, broken clerk with calcified lungs who spent his days tapping a green screen above a slag pit. It wanted real spacefarers. It wanted competence.

He had lived under a rock his entire life, nursing a delusion of grandeur, completely blind to how useless he actually was. Humanity didn't conquer the stars by handing deep-space berths to desperate forty-six-year-old nobodies just because they survived forty-five years in a tin can.

The embarrassment was worse than the rejection. It shredded the last piece of armor he had left.

Marek pulled his knees up to his chest and stared at the grey concrete wall of his compartment. All the light, color, and noise in the universe seemed to drain away, leaving behind a dull, monochrome void. The ambient hum of the station's life-support pumps sounded like a funeral dirge.

When the shift alarm chimed for Sub-Level 4, he didn't move.

Let the terminal chime every eleven minutes. Let the slag bay burn. Let the supervisor mark him down for a code violation, draft a fine, or revoke his ration credits. They had rejected him; now he rejected them.

He pulled his heavy wool blanket over his head, burying himself in the dark. He wanted to go into a coma. He wanted to sleep so deeply that the station air, the copper taste, and the memory of his own stupid, foolish ambition would simply evaporate.

He fell asleep, woke up hours later to the dark silence of his cubicle, felt the suffocating weight of reality press down on his chest, and closed his eyes again, begging his brain to shut off, slipping back into the numb, grey dark.

Environmental Logistics & The Glitch

Betty's hands were practically shaking against the cracked plastic frame of her console.

She sat in the cramped, damp cubicle of Environmental & Resource Logistics, surrounded by the dull gurgle of the gray-water recyclers running behind the bulkhead. She was supposed to be cross-referencing daily filtration throughput, but she couldn't focus worth a damn.

Her blood was boiling, every nerve inflamed by the memory of Derek.

Derek was the station's "community cohesion" liaison—a sleek, charismatic bastard with perfect teeth, clear skin, and an infuriating habit of leaning over her desk like he owned the place. Just two hours ago, in front of four junior clerks, Derek had dropped another one of his backhanded jabs right into her lap.

"Still clutching your ancient paper-slates, Betty?" he had said, flashing that smooth, empty smile that made the younger girls in the office sigh. "You know, if you spent less time yelling about household terminal limits on plastic crates and a little more time thinking about the broader asteroid ecosystem, maybe Sub-Level 2 wouldn't be three days behind on its secondary filter cycles. You're just so delightfully set in your ways, isn't that right?"

She hated him. She hated him with a raw, burning intensity that made her ears ring.

Who was he to talk about community? He was a stingy, slick corporate politician who didn't give a damn about Orestes-7; he just cared about looking good for his annual review so he could get transferred to a luxury dome on Mars. He called her close-minded, slow, selfish—just because she refused to let him quietly strip away another piece of local dignity under the banner of "station optimization."

"I'm forty years on this desk, you arrogant little snake," she muttered to herself, stabbing a finger into the keyboard. "Forty years keeping your air clean and your water drinkable while you polish your shoes."

Her mind kept replaying the scene, looping his smug, handsome face, his condescending tone, his endless lectures about the "greater good." She couldn't eat, she couldn't focus on her logs, and every time she tried to read a routine system report, Derek's voice echoed in her head.

Then, her terminal screen gave a strange, metallic click.

Betty froze. The standard blue diagnostic stream had flickered. In the center of her interface, a thick, yellow error border had locked around an automated processing ticket.

She blinked, wiping her tired eyes. She looked at it once. Then a second time. Then a third.

In forty years of sitting at the Environmental & Resource desk, Betty had never seen an actual, unprompted system error. The automated algorithms were supposed to be seamless, cold, and flawless. The human staff were just decorative thumbs legally required to sit in chairs to satisfy the 25% corporate labor quota. The machine made the choices; the human clicked 'confirm.' That was the rule.

But sitting right there on her monitor was a blatant, undeniable system logic glitch.

The central allocation engine had suffered a data-packet collision during a batch update. An automated system decision—a hard, final status determination—had been misfiled under an invalid processing tag, generating a self-contradictory logic error that the algorithm couldn't resolve on its own. The machine had reached an illegal branch in its code and was stuck in a feedback loop, attempting to execute an erroneous rejection command based on corrupted metadata.

It was a real mistake. A genuine, mechanical blind spot.

For a brief second, Betty just stared at it. The system wasn't infallible. The great, unfeeling corporate algorithm had actually stumbled.

Her forty years of deep, ingrained muscle memory took over. Without even consciously thinking about it, Betty reached across her desk and flipped open the dust cover over the physical manual override interface—a thick, yellow button that hadn't been pressed on this desk in decades.

She slammed her palm down on the REJECT SYSTEM DECISION key, overriding the automated logic loop. Then, she typed in the manual line-item correction, clearing the corrupted metadata string, and hit the heavy green CORRECTING RECORD button.

[OVERRIDE EXECUTED] RECORD CORRECTED & SYNCHRONIZED

The terminal gave a sharp, mechanical chime. The yellow error border vanished. The system accepted her human override, quietly updated the master ledger, and cleared the ticket from her queue.

The screen returned to its usual, dull blue stream.

Betty sat back in her squeaky vinyl chair, her heart thumping against her ribs. The entire action had taken less than ten seconds. It was a tiny, invisible blip in the billions of terabytes flowing through the asteroid's central node, but for a single moment, a human hand had corrected the machine.

She stared at the calm blue monitor for a long, quiet minute. The rush of adrenaline slowly faded, leaving her alone with the hum of the water pipes.

Then, her chest tightened, her brows furrowed, and her mind snapped right back to Derek's condescending, handsome face.

“Slow,” she thought bitterly, her fingers curling into fists again as she glared at the empty corridor outside her cubicle. “He called me slow...”

CHAPTER VII

The Reversal

A sharp, insistent chime cut through the dark of the cubicle, jerking Marek out of his heavy sleep.

He forced himself upright, his head spinning as he squinted at the wall monitor. The cold rejection notice was gone. In its place, a high-priority system line flashed in bright, unyielding green:

[MANUAL OVERRIDE LOGGED – STATUS: ACCEPTED]

BERTH ASSIGNED: CERES HEAVY ORE-CARRIER (DEEP-RUN AUXILIARY)
REPORT TO DOCKING BAY 3 WITHIN 48 HOURS.

Marek stood frozen in the middle of his cramped bunk room, completely dizzy and stunned. His mind went entirely blank, his eyes locked onto the impossible text, utterly overwhelmed by the sudden, unexplainable reversal of reality.